

A NOTE OF APPRECIATION
For the Book
PROMINENT PUNJABI WRITERS OF PAKISTAN
Authored by
Jasbir Singh Sarna
Publisher: Sapt Rishi, Chandigarh; First Edition: 2024
Contributed by Hardev Singh Virk

Prof. of Eminence (Hon), SGGS World University, Fatehgarh Sahib (Punjab)

Jasbir Singh Sarna is a prolific writer of Jammu area in J&K State of India. I was told by some common friend that he was awarded Doctorate by an American university on the basis of his book(s). He has written both in English and Punjabi, and his score has reached sixty published books in a short span of time. The day my article “**Five Brilliant Lady Academics of Pakistani Punjab**” appeared on Sikh Net, Jasbir sent me an email about his book under review. I asked for its Online Copy and he obliged me quickly.

As an introductory note, the author writes: *"This book is earnestly dedicated to the luminous lives and literary odysseys of these venerable pillars of Punjabi literature. In reverential homage, it unveils a portal into the profound lives and profound works of illustrious Punjabi scribes, among them, the likes of Baba Farid, Waris Shah, Shah Hussain, Bulleh Shah, Sultan Bahu, Qadar Yar, Mian Muhammad Bakhsh, and an illustrious host of others. Their verses traverse the vast expanse of themes, delving into the realms of love, spirituality, mysticism, and astute social commentary, unfurling profound and sagacious insights into the intricate tapestry of human existence."*

The book has been reviewed by Dr Harpreet Kaur, Principal Mata Sundary College, New Delhi and I read the Review in The Sikh Review, being published from Kolkatta. The reviewer concludes her review with words of appreciation for the book and its author: “In short, how human emotions find expression in various forms of literature is the main objective of Dr. Sarna and he has covered the literary mosaic in Pakistan strengthening the enduring spirit of these writers to reach to the masses and to improve the society. I congratulate him for his new publication which is interesting as well as motivating for the writers who many a times, do not get proper recognition for their seminal works”.

Mota Singh Sarai of Punjabi Sath, Walsal (UK) writes in his Page of Appreciation: “Dr Sarna's work "Prominent Punjabi Writers of Pakistan" is unique because literary figures and efforts have played a significant role in promoting unity among Punjabi writers from Pakistan. Our salute goes to Dr. Sarna's commitment and dedication. His hard work will be highly appreciated within literary circles throughout the Punjabi community”.

Dr Akhtar Hussain Sandhu, Principal, Islamia College, Lahore, writes in his note: “SALUTE OF CHARDA PUNJAB TO LEHNDA PUNJAB”: “I do appreciate the love Dr. Sarna has exhibited for Lehnda Punjab and its people. I am sure that the people of Lehnda Punjab will return the same affection to Charda Punjab following the footsteps of Dr. Jasbir Singh Sarna. I wish him a successful life with good health and respect”.

Dr Sarna has given names of 40 celebrated writers of Pakistani Punjab in contents of the book followed by 2 Appendices. It is a labour of love supported by intensive research into the archives of Pakistani literary figures who contributed not only to the survival but also promotion of Punjabi language and literature at the global level. In my estimate, there are 130 million (13 Crore) Punjabi speaking people in the world and nearly 80% live in Pakistan. It is very unfortunate that Punjabi has not been introduced as a medium of instruction in Pakistan despite the fact it is mother-tongue of bulk of the population. Urdu is being used as a national language and medium of instruction. There is a strong group of Punjabi lovers in favour of introduction of Punjabi in Shahmukhi Script.

My bird's eye view of Sarna's book reveals his vast coverage of writers in Pakistan. I personally met a few of them during my sojourn in Punjabi university Patiala (1965-79). They participated in International Punjabi Conferences organised by Punjabi University, Patiala. Ilyas Ghumman was a frequent contributor to Daily Ajit of Jalandhar and we met once in Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar during 1990s. The others whom I met in PU Patiala include Fakar Zaman, Mohammad Afzal Ahsan Randhawa, Sibtal Husan Zaigham, and of course, Nabila Rehman of Oriental College, Lahore.

I make a quantum jump to finish my note of Appreciation. I am a bit SURPRISED that none of the five brilliant Academic ladies of Pakistani Punjab, who are included in my Sikh Net article, appear in the contents of Jasbir Sarna's book. However, in Appendix I “*DIGITAL DYNAMICS AND PUNJABI CULTURAL TAPESTRY IN PAKISTAN*”, I found mention of Purva Masood and some others who are promoting Punjabi language and culture using digital media. I wish some Pakistani Scholar reciprocates the effort made by Jasbir Sarna by highlighting the contributions of Indian Punjab. It is my pleasure to mention that Safir

Rammah of APNA (Academy of Punjab in North America) is promoting Punjabi Language in both Scripts by posting new and old books of celebrated authors worldwide.